

Cutting edge: Jasprit Bumrah scalped four wickets with his swerving cutters to set up a massive win for India in the final. R.V. MOORTHY

smaller grounds with flatter tracks, batters are often afforded a greater margin for error. So, in venues like Chepauk and Eden Gardens, this variation proved to be largely ineffective.

But the Narendra Modi Stadium in Ahmedabad, with its large outfield and black-soil pitch, proved to be fertile ground for the off-cutters — producing a tournament-high 21 wickets, at a meagre 8.25 runs per over.

South Africa, which played five of its eight games in Ahmedabad, used the grippy surface to its advantage to string together a remarkable winning run through the group and Super Eight stages before eventually falling in the semifinal.

Lungi Ngidi (right) was the ringleader of the Proteas pace attack, which maximised the Ahmedabad conditions. He bowled 63 off-cutters this edition — five of his 12 wickets came with this delivery — eight more than the second-best bowler (India’s Jasprit Bumrah).

“Over the years, I’ve realised using different lengths [on slower balls] — yorker, on length or bouncer. So, it’s three different lengths with the same ball and the batter has got to guess which one’s coming next,” said Ngidi during the World Cup.

Central to Ngidi’s success was his deployment of the ‘dipping’ off-cutter, a variant that involves additional use of the wrist, in addition to the fingers, to impart more revolutions on the ball. This delivery, before its post-bounce lateral movement, also drops in length, increasing the odds of forcing a mistake from the batter.

During the T20 World Cup, Ngidi had revealed that this was something he had picked up from West Indies’ Dwayne Bravo during IPL 2018, when the two pacers were teammates at Chennai Super Kings.



Off-cutters in Men's T20 World Cups

